His exit inaugurated no sudden shower of peace and prosperity, however, but a debauchery of gore. Badauni, who was present at the scene, describes how Adham Khan and Pir Muhammad had ‘troop after troop’ of the defeated brought before them and executed, so that ‘blood flowed river upon river’. Pir Muhammad, true to form, kept up a flow of jesting commentary: ‘[W]hat a plague of a strong neck this victim has, and what a power of blood has poured from it!’ It was, writes Badauni, as if human heads were so many ‘radishes, and cucumbers, and leeks’. Disgusted and horrified by such ‘terror, like that of Judgement day’, Badauni pleaded, through a friend, for it to stop, but Pir Muhammad was unmoved – he’d taken such an abundance of prisoners overnight, where was he to put them except in their graves?[8]

In the palace of Sarangpur, meanwhile, another kind of slaughter was under way. Baz Bahadur had left instructions that, should he be defeated, his women and dancing girls were to be killed.[9] Thus, writes Abul Fazl, many of these ‘fairy-framed’ women were put to the sword; Rupmati, too, had been wounded when the imperial troops came galloping in.

They were led by Adham Khan, keen to lay his hands on Baz Bahadur’s treasures, of which his beloved Rupmati was, of course, the pearl. When the poet-sultan’s muse heard that Adham Khan had arrived, she did not wait, but ‘bravely quaffed [a] cup of deadly poison’ and left this world – thus taking ‘her honour’, notes Abul Fazl approvingly, ‘to the . . . chambers of annihilation’.

Rupmati may have escaped his unwanted attentions, but still a great bounty flowed into Adham Khan’s arms. Not only women whose ‘heart-ravishing charms were sung of in the streets’, but also all manner of ‘rare and exquisite articles . . . and buried treasures’.[10] Of this rich loot, Adham Khan sent only some elephants to Akbar.

Did Adham Khan assume that Akbar – younger than Adham and nursed all these years by Adham’s mother – lacked Adham’s worldly appreciation of gold and women, and cared only to play with elephants? Or, less patronizingly, was Adham only abiding by the conventions of conquest and income that Akbar’s father and grandfather lived by? Adham had taken Malwa so he was entitled to its riches.

~